



PRIMA Shield

Security Assessment Plan (SAP)

for

National Student Loan Data System

Security Categorization: Moderate

Version 2.0

Date

8/15/2026

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1. INTRODUCTION

The Federal Information Security Modernization Act (FISMA) requires agencies to review the security controls in their information systems. Agencies must periodically test and evaluate the effectiveness of information security policies, procedures, and practices. To assist agencies, NIST Special Publication 800-53A, *Guide for Assessing the Security Controls in Federal Information Systems*, establishes methods and procedures to assess the security controls in Federal information systems, specifically those controls listed in NIST Special Publication 800-53, *Recommended Security Controls for Federal Information Systems*. The employment of standardized assessment methods and procedures promotes more consistent, comparable, and repeatable security assessments of Federal information systems. The assessment of security controls is a critical step in the assessment and authorization process required for Agency information systems.

1.1 PURPOSE

The purpose of the Security Controls Assessment (SCA) is to evaluate and test security controls to determine the extent to which the security controls are implemented correctly, operating as intended, and producing desired outcomes with respect to meeting security requirements. This will be accomplished through the performance of an array of tests in specific security controls. Each test is designed to determine the sufficiency and effectiveness of a controlled feature or safeguard, and whether its avoidance can be prevented with a reasonable level of effort.

The test procedures will be developed to organize the test set, which will evaluate pre-specified technical security features. Test procedures specify the test evaluation criteria for each security measure (i.e., what criteria each measure must meet to be considered effective). These criteria have been derived from the [target system] documentation pertaining to the security requirements that the system was designed to satisfy, as well as to applicable government standards.

1.2 SCOPE

The scope of the assessment defined in this document covers only the [National Student Loan Data System](#), including connectivity within the system. Tests will be conducted in the areas of *Access Control, Awareness and Training, Audit and Accountability, Certification, Accreditation, and Security Assessments, Configuration Management, Contingency Planning, Identification and Authentication, Incident Response, Maintenance, Media Protection, Physical and Environmental Protection, Planning, Personnel Security, Risk Assessment, System and Services Acquisition, System and Communications Protection, and System and Information Integrity*.

Security tests are developed to evaluate the effectiveness of in-place or implemented security controls, and to determine the extent to which National Student Loan Data System security controls satisfy those requirements specified in the following publications.

1.3 LAWS, REGULATIONS, STANDARDS, AND GUIDANCE

- OMB Circular A-130, Appendix III, Security of Federal Automated Information Systems, February 8, 1996
- OMB Circular A-123 II, Management Accountability and Control, Revised June 21, 1995
- NIST SP 800-53r4, Security and Privacy Controls for Federal Information Systems and Organizations
- NIST SP 800-53r5, Security and Privacy Controls for Information Systems and organizations
- NIST SP 800-53Ar4, Assessing Security and Privacy Controls in Federal Information Systems and Organizations
- NIST SP 800-53B, Control Baselines for Information Systems and Organizations
- 5 U.S.C. 552a, Privacy Act, c. 1974
- 18 U.S.C. 1030 (a) (3), Fraud and related activity in connection with computers.
- 38 U.S.C. 901-905, Security and law enforcement on property under the jurisdiction of the Veterans Administration
- 38 U.S.C. 5701, Confidential nature of claims
- 38 U.S.C. 5705, Confidentiality of medical quality assurance records
- PL 100-322 covers the confidentiality of AIDS patients' data
- Check to see if the laws are still active

1.4 SYSTEM OVERVIEW

Table 1-0 Information System Name and Title

Unique Identifier	Information System Name	Information System Abbreviation
SYSFWY5NSDLS004	National Student Data Loan System	NSDLS

1.5 GENERAL DESCRIPTION

This section includes a general description of the [NSLDS](#).

The National Student Loan Data System (NSLDS) is the U.S. Department of Education's (ED) central database for Federal Student Aid. It aggregates and manages data from various sources including schools, guaranty agencies, the Direct Loan program, and other ED programs. NSLDS Student Access provides a centralized, integrated view of Title IV loans and grants, enabling recipients of Title IV aid to access and inquire about their loan and grant data.

Data Management and Access

NSLDS offers borrowers a comprehensive snapshot of their federal loan and grant data. To access records, users must provide their Social Security number (SSN), the first two letters of their last name, date of birth, and PIN. Through NSLDS, users can view:

- Types of loans they have
- Original amounts borrowed for each loan
- Current loan balances and statuses
- Servicer or holder of the loan

Data Composition

The records in NSLDS include:

- Student loans and grant amounts
- Outstanding balances
- Loan statuses
- Disbursements
- Enrollment information from postsecondary schools, guarantors, the Direct Loan program, and other Title IV financial aid participating organizations

System Integration and Security

NSLDS interfaces with the Federal Student Aid System (FSAS) and the Debt Management and Collections System (DMCS) for internet and intranet access. Access to NSLDS is managed based on Oracle roles and is granted by NSLDS administrators according to the principle of least privilege, ensuring users have access only to the information necessary for their job functions.

Data Handling and Support

As the central database system, NSLDS stores, processes, and transmits various types of information related to direct loans, loan guarantees, payments, federal grants, direct transfers, tax credits, reporting and information, funds control, and higher education.

Security Operations

NSLDS supports all headquarters security operations, facilitating informed decision-making and providing guidance to the headquarters security centers. This ensures the integrity and security of the data managed within the system.

Enhanced Description

NSLDS operates on a secure Oracle-based infrastructure, leveraging advanced security protocols and encryption methods to safeguard sensitive financial data. It continuously interfaces with external systems to ensure data accuracy and up-to-date records, playing a critical role in the administration and management of federal student aid programs. The system's robust architecture and comprehensive data management capabilities make it an essential tool for both federal aid administrators and aid recipients.

The NSLDS plays a vital role in the U.S. federal student loan and grant ecosystem. By providing a centralized platform for data management, NSLDS promotes transparency and accountability in financial aid distribution. It empowers students to manage their loan portfolios effectively while supporting loan services, schools, and government agencies in efficient program administration and oversight.

1.8 HARDWARE AND SOFTWARE CHANGES

There are no changes to the existing hardware and software list.

Hardware Inventory

The **NSLDS** (National Student Loan Data System) operates within a government-approved cloud infrastructure with supporting on-premises access for administrative use. The hardware components ensure data collection, processing, storage, and availability of national student loan information.

Hardware Component	Purpose/Function	Location/Hosting
Virtual Servers (Cloud-based)	Host application services and system interfaces	FedRAMP-authorized Cloud Environment
Database Servers	Manage student loan data repositories	Encrypted Virtual Storage in Cloud
Firewalls and Network Routers	Protect system perimeters and route data traffic	CSP Perimeter & Federal Agency Network Infrastructure
Backup Storage Devices	Enable business continuity and disaster recovery	Cloud Backup Services with Encryption
End-User Workstations	Access for authorized analysts and support personnel	Federal Office Premises

Software Inventory

The **NSLDS** software environment includes both COTS and custom-developed applications that support system operations, student eligibility processing, and analytics.

Software Component	Purpose/Function	Security/Compliance Note
Relational Database (Oracle/PostgreSQL)	Store, organize, and retrieve loan data	Encrypted at rest; FIPS 140-3 validated modules
NSLDS Web Portal	Public and school-based access to student loan info	Enforced HTTPS/TLS encryption
Identity and Access Management (IAM) Tools	Role-based authentication and authorization	Implement MFA and account auditing
Data Analytics Tools	Generate reports, trends, and compliance insights	Access controlled; read-only datasets
Patch and Configuration Management Tools	Keep system components secure and up to date	Monthly patch cycles and change tracking

1.9 DOCUMENT OVERVIEW

The test plan shall contain the following sections:

- **Executive Summary.** A management level overview of project objectives and purposes.
- **Introduction.** A description of the purpose and scope of this document as well as a general description of the system and the plan of content.
- **Security Controls Assessment Planning.** General description of the analytical methodology applied.
- **Security Controls Assessment Execution.** Describes the elements of the assessment procedures, the assessment expectations, and the contents of the SCA Report
- **Security Controls Assessment Methods.** Proposed test scenarios and expected system reactions.

2. SECURITY CONTROLS ASSESSMENT PLANNING

2.1 ASSESSMENT OBJECTIVES

The objective of the SCA is to provide a means for ensuring system assurance. Assurance is the grounds for confidence that the security controls implemented within an information system are effective in their application. Assurance can be obtained by actions taken by security control assessors during the testing and evaluation process to determine the extent to which the controls are implemented correctly, operating as intended, and producing the desired outcome with respect to meeting the security requirements for the system. NIST SP 800-53A provides guidance on assessment methods and procedures for security controls defined in 800-53.

Organizations must employ security controls to meet security requirements defined by laws, executive orders, directives, policies, or regulations. The security controls defined in NIST SP 800-53 are recommended for use by organizations in protecting the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of their information and information systems.

Baseline controls are the minimum-security controls recommended for an information system based on the system's security categorization in accordance with FIPS 199. Three sets of baseline security controls have been identified corresponding to the low-impact, moderate-impact, and high-impact levels defined in the security categorization process in FIPS 199. Each of the three baselines provides a minimum set of security controls for a particular impact level associated with a security category.

2.2 ASSESSMENT FRAMEWORK

The concept for assessing security controls begins with the input of the security control number from NIST SP 800-53 and the security categorization baseline. The appropriate assessment methods will then be applied to the security control and baseline. This will generate an assessment procedure in the form of a checklist of activities or actions for the assessor. The procedure generated by the assessment framework will automatically consider such factors as scope, coverage, depth, and assurance with respect to the assessment methods employed.

2.3 ASSESSMENT METHODS

There are three assessment methods associated with security controls:

- **Interview:** The process of conducting focused discussions with organizational personnel to facilitate understanding, achieve clarification, or obtain evidence
- **Examine:** The process of checking, inspecting, reviewing, observing, studying, or analyzing an assessment object to generate a verdict or to reach a conclusion
- **Test:** The process of exercising an assessment object under specified conditions, observing, and recording the results, and comparing the actual with the expected behavior

2.3.1 Interview

Definition: The process of conducting focused discussions with organizational personnel to facilitate understanding, achieve clarification, or obtain evidence.

Assessment objects: Individuals or groups

2.3.2 Examine

Definition: The process of checking, inspecting, reviewing, observing, studying, or analyzing an assessment object to generate a verdict or to reach a conclusion.

Assessment objects: Specifications, Activities, Mechanisms

2.3.3 Test

Definition: The process of exercising an assessment object under specified conditions, observing and recording the results, and comparing the actual with the expected behavior.

Assessment objects: Activities, Mechanisms

2.4 EVALUATION CRITERIA

The results of each assessment procedure will be categorized into one of three ratings:

- **Fully Satisfied (FS)** – The stated test objective is met.
- **Not Satisfied (NS) OR Other Than Satisfied**– The stated test objective is not met.
- **Not Applicable (NA)** – The test objective is not applicable at the time of testing.

All failures will be documented and included in the **SCA Report**. Any test objective identified as **Not Satisfied** will also be documented and included in the **SCA Report**.

2.5 SECURITY CONTROL ASSESSMENT (SCA) TEAM COMPOSITION

The SCA Team will consist of an **SCA, Kwasi Mantey**, and three or four team members [Contractors]. The Team will possess a thorough understanding of [National Student Loan Data System](#) security operational capabilities and a solid information security background, including relevant security documentation.

Selected personnel from system stakeholders will assist the **SCA Team** in this exercise. This group will consist of representatives of major areas of security controls that are to be tested. Access to and availability of these people is the responsibility of the system stakeholders. Technical Point of Contact from the system stakeholders' personnel will assist the **SCA Team** by performing online demonstrations when required, retrieving all backup support documentation, and assisting in all inspections according to the agreed-upon agenda.

Specific individuals whose presence is required and specific documentation to which the **SCA Team** will need access will be provided before the beginning of testing. At a minimum, there should be a qualified individual, preferably at a senior level, in each of the areas listed below:

- **Information Security Officer (ISO).** A member of the system stakeholder management who is currently involved with the [National Student Loan Data System](#) security
- **System Administrator.** An individual who is familiar with the operation of the system component is responsible for administering. This individual should be able to review and evaluate the functional and operational capabilities of the [National Student Loan Data System](#) equipment, operating system, and software utilities
- **Program Manager.** An individual who is involved with the development and ongoing management of the system

2.5.1 Duties of SCA Team Leader

The SCA Team Leader is fully dedicated to planning, managing, and executing the SCA effort. Some of the management requirements for the Team Leader are summarized in the following paragraphs.

- Work closely with stakeholder personnel. The Team Leader has the authority to make assignments and ensure that they are carried out.
- Schedule regular meetings with other SCA team members and document the results throughout the testing period.
- Carefully plan and schedule every step of the SCA process. Planning and Team organization are essential to a successful SCA exercise.
- Execute the agreed-upon agenda.

The members of the SCA Team are found in Table 2-1 SCA Security Testing Team.

Table 2-1 SCA Security Testing Team

Name	Role	Contact Information
Maria Rosemond	Control Assessor	203-881-8881
Kwasi Mantey	Control Assessor	203-882-8882
Labisi Akande	Control Assessor	203-883-8883
Peter Mensah	Control Assessor	203-884-8884
Isaac Brako	Control Assessor	203-885-8885

2.5.2 Responsibilities of SCA Team Members

Before conducting any tests, the **SCA Team** will review the appropriate background information and references for the area being tested. Team members will become familiar with the basic principles and requirements of the automated security controls to be tested. Some of the requirements of the SCA Team members are listed below.

- Clearly understand the members' individual SCA Team function.
- Understand the method to be used to collect the test data, to execute test procedures, and to apply evaluation criteria in the assigned test area.
- Clearly understand the purpose and functions of the security features to be evaluated.
- Review the test procedures and verify that each procedure will produce valid test results and that the results will provide a reliable basis for recommending additional security safeguards if applicable.
- Be familiar with the SCA test schedule and know the Point of Contact and time of appointment with the personnel in the operation being evaluated.
- Organize the test procedures in a logical sequence so that the security features for the system are fully assessed against the criteria.
- Report each tested security feature after a consensus is reached by the Test Team personnel who have assessed the security feature.

2.5.3 SCA Team Training

The members of the **SCA Team** shall be thoroughly trained in all facets of conducting an SCA. They will have received training in the areas of data processing, security policy, procedures, responsibilities, and the recognition of security weaknesses, vulnerabilities, and deficiencies.

2.6 ASSESSMENT SCHEDULE

A test schedule will be developed at the **kick-off meeting** to establish a timetable for the execution of the Assessment Plan. The agenda will identify the timetable for meetings and execution of specific tests, time demands on each resource, and special test requirements, if any.

The security assessment testing schedule can be found in **Error! Reference source not found.**Below.

Table 21 Assessment Estimated Timeline

Information Security Program Office Schedule	Duration (days)	Start Date	Finish Date
System Name: National Student Data Loan System			
System Acronym: NSDLS			
Unique Identifier: SYSFWY5NSDLS004			
Authority to Operate (ATO) Expiration Date (if applicable): N/A			
Assessment Type: Assessment supporting system Initial Authorization			
Assessment Kickoff Meeting			
Kick-off Meeting	1	10/22/2025	10/22/2025
Develop draft Security Assessment Plan (SAP)	3	10/23/2025	10/27/2025
Submit the final SAP to Stakeholders for review and approval	2	10/28/2025	10/29/2025
Security Control Assessment (SCA)			
Conduct Security Control Assessment (SCA) Exercise	3 Wks	10/30/2025	12/2/2025
Security Assessment Report (SAR)			
Develop draft Security Assessment Report (SAR)	3	12/3/2025	12/5/2025
SAR Issue Resolution Meeting	1	12/6/2025	12/6/2025
Submit Final SAR to Stakeholders for review and approval	2	12/7/2025	12/9/2025
Post Security Assessment			
SCA Team submits SAR to Chief Information Security Officer (CISO) /AO	5	12/10/2025	12/14/2025
CISO / AO SAR Review	5	12/15/2025	12/19/2025

3. SECURITY CONTROLS ASSESSMENT EXECUTION

3.1 STRUCTURE

The broad scope of the desired SCA necessitates careful organization and planning. The test plan has thus been structured in such a way that testing can be performed efficiently, the same structure can be used for collecting test results, and the structure can be used to validate the completeness of the test.

Specific tests have been developed to evaluate security controls in the following seventeen (17) areas or families:

Table 3: Security Control Families

ID	FAMILY	ID	FAMILY
AC	Access Control	MP	Media Protection
AT	Awareness and Training	PE	Physical and Environmental Protection
AU	Audit and Accountability	PL	Planning
CA	Security Assessment and Authorization	PS	Personnel Security
CM	Configuration Management	RA	Risk Assessment
CP	Contingency Planning	SA	System and Services Acquisition
IA	Identification and Authentication	SC	System and Communications Protection
IR	Incident Response	SI	System and Information Integrity
MA	Maintenance	PM	Program Management

3.2 ASSESSMENT PROCEDURE ELEMENTS

The assessment procedures include the following:

- **Security Control.** The control with which the system is being assessed must comply, along with the NIST security family identifier
- **Assessment Method.** The method, Interview, Examine, Test, is used to conduct the assessment
- **Assessment Object.** The object, Individuals, Groups, Specifications, Activities, and Mechanisms, of the assessment
- **Security Baseline.** The Low, Moderate, and High security categorization
- **Assessment Procedure.** The criteria by which the feature shall be evaluated
- **Expected Result.** Expected results of the assessment
- **Result.** The actual result: Fully Satisfied, Not Satisfied, Not Applicable

3.3 EXPECTATIONS

The security categorization baseline determines the level of method attributes and assessment expectations for each assessment object.

3.3.1 Low-Impact Information Systems

Interviews, examinations, and tests are conducted at a cursory level of depth and seek to ensure that there are no obvious errors in the security control.

3.3.2 Moderate-Impact Information Systems

Interviews, examinations, and tests are conducted at an exploratory level of depth and seek to ensure that the security control is implemented correctly and is operating as intended.

3.3.3 High-Impact Information Systems

Interviews, examinations, and tests are conducted at a comprehensive level of depth and seek to ensure that the security control is implemented correctly and operating as intended on a continuous and consistent basis, with continuous improvement in control effectiveness.

3.3.4 Risk Level

Each finding is categorized as a business risk and assigned a risk level rating described as high-, moderate-, or low-risk. The rating is an assessment of the priority with which each vulnerability should be addressed. Based on [NSDLS's](#) current implementation of the underlying technology and the assessment guidelines contained in the [NSDLS reporting Procedure for Information System \(IS\) Assessments](#) document, [Maria Rosemond](#) will assign these values to each Business Risk. The risk ratings are described in Table 3.2.

Table 3.2. Risk Definitions

Rating	Definition of Risk Rating
High Risk	Exploitation of technical or procedural vulnerability will cause substantial harm to the Department of Education's business processes. Significant political, financial, and legal damage is likely to result.
Moderate Risk	Exploitation of a technical or procedural vulnerability will significantly impact the confidentiality, integrity, and/or availability of the system or data. Exploitation of a vulnerability may cause moderate financial loss or public embarrassment to the Department of Education .
Low Risk	Exploitation of technical or procedural vulnerability will cause minimal impact to the Department of Education operations. The confidentiality, integrity, and availability of sensitive information are not at risk of compromise. Exploitation of vulnerability may cause slight financial loss or public embarrassment.

3.4 SECURITY CONTROLS ASSESSMENT REPORT

The **SCA Results Report** will identify the test, evaluate the effectiveness of the security control, and determine residual risk. The SCA Results Report will also identify the results of the testing and the recommended improvements to correct failed controls. The SCA Report will also include a statement for the system identifying recommendations regarding certification.

The test procedure results in the SCA Report will include the following information:

- **Security Control Number.** The security control number refers to the families of security controls as described in NIST SP 800-53
- **Requirement.** Security control from NIST SP 800-53
- **Risk Level.** Level of risk if the finding is not mitigated
- **Recommendation.** The recommended mitigation

4. TRACEABILITY MATRIX

Traceability between the required security capability (confidentiality, integrity, and availability), the required security controls enabling this capability, and the methods used to confirm security control implementation are documented in the Control Implementation section in the [National Student Data Loan System](#) SSP.

5. SECURITY ASSESSMENT RESULTS

The technical and non-technical findings associated with testing will be identified via the information gathering and testing techniques described. SCA Team will review the test results for the system and evaluate them against the specific test objectives and the applicable security requirements of the test performed.

The assessments for each security control will be documented within the approved **GRC Tool**. The compliance status (compliant, non-compliant, or not applicable), implementation status (inherited, implemented, or planned), narrative, and attachments will be completed for each security control tested. *Any security control found to be non-compliant will be identified in the Plan of Action and Milestones (POA&M).*

6. VULNERABILITY SCANNING

Automated system scan results and evaluations will be uploaded to the applicable security control (e.g., **RA-5, Vulnerability Scanning**, etc.). Any unresolved findings will be identified in the POA&M.

7. RULES OF ENGAGEMENT

A Rules of Engagement (RoE) document is designed to describe proper notifications and disclosures between the owner of a tested system and the team of independent assessors.

The ROE is established before the start of a security test and gives the test team authority to conduct defined activities without the need for additional permissions. Together with the information provided in preceding sections of this document, this document shall serve as a RoE once signed.

Disclosures

Any testing will be performed in accordance with terms and conditions designed to minimize risk exposure that could occur during security testing.

Security Testing Will Not Include

Security testing will not include any of the following activities:

- Changes to assigned user passwords
- Modification of user files or system files
- Denial of service attacks
- Exploits that will introduce new weaknesses to the system
- Intentional introduction of malicious code (viruses, Trojans, worms, etc.)

8. END OF TESTING

[SCA Team](#) will notify the **System Owner** at the [Department of Education](#) when security testing has been completed. This may be the same date the security control assessment is completed.

9. SIGNATURES

The **SCA Team Lead** and **System Owner** have been identified as having the authority to agree to the security testing of **NSDLS**.

ACCEPTANCE AND SIGNATURE			
I have read the above Security Assessment Plan and Rules of Engagement , and I acknowledge and agree to the tests and terms outlined in the plan.			
SCA Team Lead Kwasi Mantey	Kwasi Mantey	KWASI MANTEY	10/26/2025
System Owner	Taylor Dean	<i>Taylordean</i>	10/28/2025